Guitar Exercises - Section XV, Level 100

Motif Generation, Harmonic Constraints, Bass-First/Melody-First Writing, and Eight-Bar Composition

Level 100 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. Section XV begins here. HARD STOP after Level 105.

The student now becomes the source of the musical material. The goal is not unrestricted inspiration; it is learning to create coherent music deliberately from small, testable decisions.

Module	Exercise	Events
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E	Bass-first composition	128
F	Rhythm-first composition	112
G	Constraint-based eight-bar composition laboratory	160
H	Four complete eight-bar original studies	192
I	Thirty-two-bar composition portfolio capstone	320
J	Revision and authorship audit	64
	TOTAL	1520

Core rule: generate little, develop deeply.

Reference - Composition Hierarchy

Layer	Question
Constraint	What am I deliberately limiting?
Identity	What motif/rhythm/bass behavior makes this piece itself?
Harmony	What creates direction and arrival?
Development	How does the idea change without disappearing?
Contrast	What new information arrives later?
Form	When does material return?
Arrangement	Which register/texture/role presents it?
Revision	What can be removed without losing identity?

Constraints reduce random choice and make authorship easier to evaluate.

Module A - Motif Seeds

Seed	Degrees	Rhythm
1	1-2-3	quarter-quarter-half
2	1-3-5	eighth-eighth-quarter
3	5-3-2-1	four eighths
4	1-b3-4-5	syncopated eighths
5	3-2-1-7	quarter-eighth-eighth-half
6	1-5-b7-5	3+3+2 accents
7	1-2-b3-5	triplet + quarter
8	5-6-7-1	four equal notes

Choose a key only after the contour and rhythm can be sung. Then realize each seed in two registers.

Module A - Rhythm-Only Motifs

Cell	Contacts
A	1, &2, 4
B	1, a1, &3
C	&1, 2, &4
D	1, &1, a2, 4
E	3+3+2 eighth grouping
F	triplet on beat 1, rest beat 2, quarter beats 3-4
G	one attack then 3-beat sustain
H	half-bar silence then 3-note pickup

Apply the same rhythm to three different pitch contours. The rhythm should remain recognizable.

Module B - Motif Transformation

Transformation	Keep	Change
Transposition	interval/rhythm identity	starting pitch
Sequence	contour	scale-degree level
Rhythmic augmentation	pitch order	durations longer
Rhythmic diminution	pitch order	durations shorter
Inversion	rhythmic identity	up/down contour
Retrograde	rhythm or pitch set	order
Register shift	pitch classes/rhythm	octave
Truncation	opening identity	remove ending

After each transformation, play original then variant. If the relationship is no longer audible, restore one identity feature.

Module B - Development Ladder

Bars	Instruction
1-2	state motif exactly
3-4	transpose or sequence
5-6	change rhythm but retain contour
7	truncate motif
8	restore original or cadence version

Write four different eight-bar developments from one three- or four-note motif.

Module C - Harmony-First Constraints

Constraint	Eight-bar assignment
Only I-IV-V	create contrast without new chords
No V-I cadence	find alternate arrival
One common tone in every chord	voice-leading drives progression
Chromatic mediant once	make it sound intentional
Descending bass only	harmony follows bass direction
Pedal tone for 4 bars	harmony changes above fixed note
One secondary dominant	prepare one destination
Two chords only	rhythm/register create form

Write the functional progression first, then voicings, then melody.

Module C - Harmonic Direction Audit

Question	Pass condition
Where is tonic?	listener can identify home
Where is strongest departure?	one section/bar feels least settled
Where is cadence?	arrival is audible
What voice leads most clearly?	name bass/guide/common tone
Which chord is optional?	remove it and compare
Does bar 8 close or turn around?	intentional answer

A progression is not finished merely because eight chord symbols have been written.

Module D - Melody-First Writing

Pass	Task
1	sing 4-8 bar melody with no guitar
2	write contour and rhythm
3	identify strong-beat notes
4	choose chords supporting those notes
5	test alternate bass under same melody
6	reduce harmony to bass + melody
7	add inner voices only if useful

Do not change the melody merely because the first chord grip is inconvenient.

Module D - One Melody, Four Harmonizations

Version	Constraint
1	diatonic only
2	one secondary dominant
3	one borrowed/chromatic chord
4	bass line determines reharmonization
5	sparse: maximum two chords per four bars
6	dense: one chord per bar

Rank versions by melody support, bass direction, cadence strength, and distinctiveness.

Module E - Bass-First Composition

Bass design	Assignment
Stepwise descent	write harmony above C-B-A-G-F-E-D-G
Stepwise ascent	A-B-C-D-E-F-G-A
Pedal	A held/repeated for four bars
Root/fifth alternation	country/Americana engine
Chromatic approach	destination roots on beats 1
Syncopated riff	harmony implied by bass rhythm
Contrary to melody	bass down while melody rises
Sparse roots	melody supplies harmonic color

Sing a possible top line while playing bass before adding chords.

Module E - Bass/Harmony Independence

Pass	Bass	Harmony
1	fixed	roots only
2	fixed	triads
3	fixed	7th chords
4	fixed	alternate inversions
5	simplified	retain harmonic function
6	new bass	retain top melody

The bass line is compositional material, not merely the bottom note of a chord grip.

Module F - Rhythm-First Composition

Groove engine	Constraint
Funk	one 2-beat syncopated cell for 8 bars
Rock	one pedal/accent riff, three variations
Reggae	offbeat pattern; harmony changes without changing rhythm
Shuffle	triplet spacing; motif enters every 2 bars
Soul	backbeat shell + one answer window
Country	alternating bass/chord engine
Interlock	upper repeated cell around bass space
Jam-band	one motif, density changes only

Write rhythm first on muted strings. Add harmony only after the groove has identity.

Module F - Same Harmony, Four Rhythmic Identities

Use | Am7 | Fmaj7 | Cmaj7 | G7 | x2.

Version	Rhythmic identity
1	straight eighth rock
2	sparse soul backbeat
3	offbeat reggae
4	16th funk
5	shuffle
6	jam-band motif + space

The chord progression stays unchanged. The composition should feel substantially different because rhythm is structural.

Module G - Eight-Bar Constraint Laboratory

Card	Required constraints
1	3-note motif; only 2 chords; one full-bar rest
2	descending bass; melody rises; no V-I
3	pedal tone bars 1-4; chromatic mediant bar 5
4	rhythm-first; same chord 4 bars; register creates contrast
5	melody-first; one common tone across all harmony
6	bass-first; one secondary dominant; sparse melody
7	motif inversion in bars 5-6; original returns bar 8
8	one articulation family only; dynamics create climax

Complete all eight cards. Do not revise while generating the first draft; revise only after a full eight bars exist.

Module H - Study 1 - Motif first

Create one 4-note motif. Bars 1-2 exact, 3-4 sequence, 5-6 inversion, 7 truncate, 8 cadence/rest.

Pass	Requirement
1	source material only
2	complete first draft
3	identity audit
4	one revision
5	performance arrangement
6	record + self-critique

Module H - Study 2 - Melody first

Sing melody first. Harmonize twice: diatonic and one-chromatic-chord version.

Pass	Requirement
1	source material only
2	complete first draft
3	identity audit
4	one revision
5	performance arrangement
6	record + self-critique

Module H - Study 3 - Bass first

Write an 8-bar bass line with one pedal section and one chromatic approach. Harmony follows.

Pass	Requirement
1	source material only
2	complete first draft
3	identity audit
4	one revision
5	performance arrangement
6	record + self-critique

Module H - Study 4 - Rhythm first

Create a 2-beat muted rhythm cell, repeat through 8 bars, and use register/density for form.

Pass	Requirement
1	source material only
2	complete first draft
3	identity audit
4	one revision
5	performance arrangement
6	record + self-critique

Module I - Thirty-Two-Bar Composition Portfolio Capstone

Bars	Piece	Starting method	Requirement
1-8	Piece A	motif-first	develop one small melodic identity
9-16	Piece B	melody-first	same melody, chosen harmonization
17-24	Piece C	bass-first	bass motion drives harmony
25-32	Piece D	rhythm-first	groove identity drives form

Create four independent eight-bar originals. Each must have a title/working label, one-sentence identity statement, lead sheet, performance arrangement, and recorded take.

Module J - Revision and Authorship Audit

Question	Action
What is the piece's smallest recognizable identity?	circle it
Which bar is weakest?	rewrite only that bar first
Which note/chord is unnecessary?	remove it
Where is the climax?	make only that area strongest
Does bar 8 close or continue?	choose intentionally
Can the piece survive 50% fewer notes?	test reduction
Does it sound like an exercise?	add contrast or asymmetry with purpose
Can you perform it from memory?	if no, simplify identity

Pass Level 100: 14/16 or better across identity, development, harmony, melody/bass relationship, rhythm, form, revision, and performance. No zero in identity, development, form, or performance.

Next: Level 101 develops larger form: A/B sections, verse/chorus contrast, bridges, transitions, thematic return, and 16-32 bar original composition.

Fixed roadmap: 100-104 Composition; 105 Final Musicianship Capstone. HARD STOP after Level 105.